

A LONG WAY Priyanka Bose and Mohit Agarwal in *Agra*

CINEMA

AGRA STATE OF MIND

***Kanu Behl's** second feature, **Agra**, which will debut at Cannes, explores the themes of insanity and male sexual desire*



By director Kanu Behl's own admission, the protagonist in his second feature, *Agra*, is up to no good. Guru (newcomer Mohit Agarwal), a sexually repressed twentysomething man, does "dastardly things" and has a "difficult gaze", but Behl and his co-writer Atika Chohan hope to garner some empathy for him amidst the drama. The 'Agra' of the title isn't just a reference to the backdrop but also to Guru's state of mind, which others equate to the residents of the city's infamous mental asylum. "Guru has his own bizarre method of saying what is wrong in the house," Behl says. That's not to absolve other occupants as saints. Adds Behl, "It is like being inside a madhouse with six crazy people...they are as mad, if not more, as him. They refuse to acknowledge their secret lives."

Like Behl's debut film *Titli* (2014), *Agra* will have its world premiere at the prestigious Cannes Film Festival, though this time in the Director's Fortnight section. It's a fortunate happenstance, but one that Behl makes clear is not his goal. "The aim never is to make a film for a film festival," he says. "I make films to be as honest as possible and while doing that to be able to start a broader conversation with a larger audience." The topics that Behl explores in the film *Agra* include the roots of male sexual repression and "what desire does to us when we find it right in the middle of the most intimate physical connection that we can have with another person".

Apart from the Cannes screening, *Agra* is also newsworthy for it features *Aashiqui* (1990) actor Rahul Roy, who plays the family patriarch a.k.a. Daddy. Talking about the casting, Behl noted the